

AI Literacy

POD 1 - Why are we here?

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Hi, and welcome to the course!

It is a well-known fact that Artificial Intelligence is now appearing almost everywhere in our daily lives, from the way our phone can recognise our face in order to unlock it, to the invisible way that thousands of spam emails are automatically filtered for us, so that we don't get to see them in our inboxes.

Artificial Intelligence is also present in our use of Google Maps for navigation and in the way that Netflix, Spotify and online shopping recommendations are created for us.

In healthcare and in wellness there are even more uses of Artificial Intelligence, from help with the automated and semi-automated analysis of diagnostic scans, to wellness apps and devices like Fitbits which are used for step counting and for sleep monitoring.

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There are many definitions of Artificial Intelligence and most of them would be correct but a very simple way to regard AI is that it is when machines or computers try to mimic the way that humans think and make decisions, except that unlike humans, AI can do this consistently and repeatedly, and sometimes it can do this even better than what humans can.



As an example of how embedded Artificial Intelligence is in our lives, many of us use some form of social media platform, whether it is Facebook, or TikTok, or Instagram or whatever, and in each of these your “feed” or the list of posts that appear on your feed are unique to you and are chosen by an AI algorithm.

Often it feels like the algorithm seems to know exactly what you want to see and that is because it is designed that way, its aim is to keep you on that social media platform for as long as possible.

That selection of posts for your feed is also Artificial Intelligence at play and if it is used by social media companies to determine what you see in your news and in your social media feeds, then you can see how important it is to have some understanding of how it works, which is why you are taking this course.

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Apart from your own curiosity about wanting to learn about new things and trying to understand how things might work, there are a couple of other reasons for taking this course.

The first of those reasons is that most of our students are already using AI in some form as part of their learning, and they are especially using Generative AI. Our first year undergraduate students, for example, get a base level of AI literacy from participating in the course entitled “A Digital Edge” which they take, while our research students acquire their basic AI literacy from the Research Integrity course which they all have to take. So it follows that if our students are learning about AI, then we should too.

A second reason for taking this course is that as part of the European Union’s AI Act which is now law throughout the European Union, all organisations which deploy the use of AI -- and that includes DCU -- needs to introduce training and development programs to enhance the level of AI literacy among its employees. In our case this should cover the basics of AI, some applications in education, and its ethical and societal implications.



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In this course we do this through a combination of theoretical and practical training by giving a foundation of basic AI knowledge coupled with some practical experience through hands-on learning. This means that you will get both a better understanding of how AI functions and some real experience using some of the most common Generative AI tools.

The hands-on exercises are designed to allow you to explore AI in relation to things in your daily life that you are already interested in like your hobbies or your other activities.

Finally, in this course we are delighted to welcome four of DCU's world-recognised leading experts in Artificial Intelligence and each of them will give us a short presentation covering various sub-topics.

Each of these presenters have been working on AI for many years and each are at the forefront of the development and the use of Artificial Intelligence, so we are delighted to be able to avail of their expertise and experience.

Let's get started.